

# Too Coherent to Be Real

Szukalski, Creative Obstinacy, Documentary Unreality,  
and the Problem of the Frictionless Subject

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## Abstract

This essay begins with an unusual perceptual experience: watching a documentary about the Polish sculptor Stanisław Szukalski and being left uncertain whether he actually existed. The film is so well-made, its subject so perfectly illustrative of everything a documentary about outsider genius, nationalist tragedy, and late redemption would want him to be, that the viewer's reality-testing mechanism fires not on any implausible detail but on the overall gestalt. Szukalski is too coherent. His contradictions resolve too cleanly. The care with which he has been preserved produces, paradoxically, a figure who feels constructed rather than encountered. The essay uses this experience as an entry point into three interconnected arguments. First, that Szukalski's creative obstinacy — his systematic refusal of outside influence — was not mere eccentricity but a survival strategy, a form of procedural memory maintenance under conditions of institutional destruction. Second, drawing on Catherine Liu's analysis of infantilization, affect, and the professional managerial class, that total mediation produces unreality: a subject with no friction, no resistance to the narrative containing him, becomes indistinguishable from a fabrication regardless of whether he was real. Third, that these two observations are connected by a deeper structural claim: the conditions that make creative work durable — obstinacy, refusal of absorption, maintenance of idiosyncratic form — are also the conditions that make a person difficult to document without flattening. The essay concludes by reading Szukalski's Zermatism — his theory of a single origin language and a debased lineage of humanity — as an armillary proposal gone pathological: a coordinate transformation that kept rotating past the point where it could encounter resistance from reality, and thereby became unfalsifiable in the same way the egg-avatar politics Liu diagnoses becomes unfalsifiable: sealed against the friction that would have made it real.

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## The Unreality Effect

There is a specific perceptual experience that well-made documentaries about eccentric geniuses can produce in the attentive viewer: the growing suspicion that the subject did not exist. This is not the ordinary skepticism one brings to historical claims. It is something stranger. The figure on screen is too perfectly illustrative of everything the film needs them to be. Their contradictions are too narratively productive. Their tragedy is too clean. The people who loved them remember them with exactly the combination of wonder, sorrow, and complicated loyalty that the film requires. And gradually the viewer's reality-testing mechanism, which usually fires on implausible details, begins to fire instead on the overall coherence of the construction. The subject is too much like what a subject of this kind would be like.

Stanisław Szukalski produces this effect. He is a Polish sculptor born in 1893 who developed a distinctive and obsessive visual language, was celebrated in inter-war Poland, lost his entire Warsaw studio and nearly his entire life's work to the Nazi bombing of 1939, emigrated to Los Angeles, lived in obscurity for decades, and was rediscovered in his old age by a circle of admirers including George DiCaprio, who preserved his remaining work and recorded his conversation. He also held nationalist and antisemitic views in the years surrounding the Second World War, views he later repudiated. He created a theory of human cultural origins he called Zermatism, which posited that all human languages descended from a single primordial tongue he called Protong, and that humanity's debasement arose from prehistoric interbreeding with sea creatures.

Presented as a list of facts, this is simply unusual. Presented as a documentary, with archival photographs, interviews with devoted survivors, and footage of the actual sculptures — gnarly, mythological, technically extraordinary — the unreality effect intensifies rather than diminishes. The more evidence accumulates, the more the figure feels assembled. He is too complete. The tragedy of the lost Warsaw work, the obscurity, the late rescue, the moral complexity of the nationalism — each element fulfills a narrative function so precisely that the whole begins to feel authored.

This essay begins with that perceptual experience because it is philosophically interesting in itself, and because it leads directly into questions that are larger than any one documentary: questions about creative obstinacy as a survival strategy, about the relationship between documentation and reality, about what kinds of subjects resist the flattening that total mediation produces, and about when the refusal of outside influence becomes not a condition of creative survival but a sealed system that can no longer encounter the world on its own terms.

## Szukalski's Obstinacy as Survival Strategy

The standard reading of an outsider artist's refusal of influence is psychological: eccentricity, grandiosity, incapacity for the ordinary social negotiations that participation in an artistic community requires. This reading is not entirely wrong in Szukalski's case. He was by all accounts difficult, domineering, convinced of his own exceptional status in ways that made sustained collaboration nearly impossible.

But the psychological reading misses the structural function of the refusal. Szukalski's obstinacy — his insistence on developing a visual and theoretical vocabulary entirely his own, his resistance to assimilation into any existing artistic movement, his cultivation of a mythology of himself as the lone bearer of a suppressed primordial tradition — was not only a personality trait. It was a form of institutional independence. And institutional independence, as the history of the twentieth century repeatedly demonstrated, was a condition of survival.

An artist whose work is legible within an existing movement, marketable through existing institutional channels, comprehensible to existing critical frameworks, is also an artist whose work is vulnerable to the institutional forces that shape and destroy those frameworks. The Warsaw bombing of 1939 destroyed Szukalski's studio, his archive, and the physical record of decades of work. What it could not destroy was the procedural knowledge carried in his hands and his mind: the specific techniques, the mythological vocabulary, the obsessive formal investigations that constituted his practice. That knowledge survived because it was his alone. There was no school of Szukalski, no workshop tradition, no institutional structure through which the work was mediated and which could have been infiltrated or corrupted or simply closed.

The artist who refuses absorption preserves something that institutions cannot destroy, because institutions cannot absorb what they cannot recognize. Szukalski's idiosyncrasy was not an obstacle to his survival. It was its mechanism.

This is the inverse of the standard account of institutional memory. In most analyses, procedural knowledge is preserved through transmission — through workshops, apprenticeships, training programs, communities of practice. When those transmission mechanisms are destroyed, the knowledge is lost. Szukalski's case suggests a complementary but different dynamic: knowledge can also be preserved through radical concentration in a single carrier who is too idiosyncratic to be absorbed by any institution and therefore cannot be destroyed when institutions are destroyed.

The cost of this strategy is obvious. Knowledge preserved through radical con-

centration in a single carrier is also knowledge that cannot be transmitted through normal channels, that depends entirely on the carrier's survival and willingness to continue, and that is vulnerable to exactly the death and dispersal that eventually claimed Szukalski's unreproduced work. The DiCaprio circle's preservation effort is, in the framework developed in recent work on institutional memory, an attempt at approximate repair under conditions of operational fiber death: the procedural knowledge that was Szukalski's alone has decayed to measure zero, and what remains is declarative knowledge — photographs, recordings, the surviving sculptures — from which the full practice cannot be reconstructed, only imagined.

### **The Egg Avatar and Its Inverse**

Catherine Liu, in conversation about her work on the professional managerial class and the culture of liberal affect, describes a figure she calls the egg avatar: the undifferentiated online subject who has cultivated maximum receptivity to feeling at the cost of the ego boundaries that would allow actual confrontation with the world. The egg avatar is soft, porous, constantly vibing, constitutionally incapable of the friction that distinguishes real encounter from mutual affect-resonance. When egg avatars collide, they do not disagree; they fear cracking. The political consequence is an inability to build anything that requires sustained conflict, institutional structure, or the tolerance of contradiction.

Liu is drawing on a psychoanalytic tradition that distinguishes between the ego — the mediating structure between id and superego, capable of engaging with external reality — and the pre-differentiated infantile surface that precedes ego formation. Her argument is that a significant strand of contemporary progressive culture has sacralized the pre-differentiated state, treating the porousness and receptivity of the undifferentiated infant as a political and aesthetic ideal rather than a developmental starting point to be moved through.

Szukalski is the opposite of an egg. He is what happens when differentiation proceeds without external check — when the ego boundary is maintained and reinforced and elaborated until it becomes a totalizing system that can no longer register feedback from outside itself. If the egg avatar's pathology is the inability to sustain boundaries, Szukalski's pathology is the inability to relax them. Where the egg avatar dissolves into collective affect, Szukalski constructed an entire cosmology as an extension of his own self-understanding. Zermatism is not a theory that could be falsified by evidence because it was not primarily a theory about the world; it was a theory about Szukalski's position in relation to the world, and evidence that failed to confirm it was evidence of the debased condition the theory was designed to diagnose.

The egg avatar and the totalizing obsessive are not opposites in the sense of correcting each other. They are mirror pathologies of the same failure of mediation: one has no boundary, the other has a boundary that has become a wall.

Liu's framework implies that what is needed is not more differentiation or less differentiation but the right kind: the ego as mediating term, capable of sustaining conflict without dissolution, capable of encountering the world without becoming the world. Szukalski had enormous ego strength in the psychoanalytic sense — he sustained his practice through decades of obscurity, institutional destruction, and exile — but his ego had long since ceased to mediate between his inner world and external reality. It had become, instead, a system for interpreting external reality as confirmation of an already-complete internal theory.

This is where his nationalism and antisemitism cease to be incidental biographical facts and become structurally interesting. A mind that has developed a totalizing cosmological system — Zermatism, Protong, the theory of prehistoric debasement — is a mind that has solved the problem of outside influence by eliminating the category of outside. Everything becomes interpretable within the system. The antisemitism is not a separate module added to an otherwise coherent worldview; it is what a Zermatist interpretation of early twentieth century European politics produces when the interpretive frame has become sealed. Szukalski did eventually repudiate these views, which suggests the frame was not entirely impermeable. But the repudiation came late and appears to have been experienced as a correction from outside rather than an internal revision — the kind of encounter with recalcitrant reality that a more porous ego structure would have enabled earlier.

### **What the Documentary Cannot Show**

The documentary about Szukalski is made by people who love him. Glenn Bray, who preserved the work; George DiCaprio, who befriended him in his Los Angeles years; others who experienced his personality directly and who carry genuine grief about what was lost in Warsaw. Their testimony is authentic. Their care for the man and his work is unmistakable.

And yet this care is precisely what produces the unreality effect. Total mediation through love creates a subject without friction. The Szukalski we see in the documentary has been selected, arranged, and preserved by people whose relationship to him was one of devotion. His difficult qualities — the domineering personality, the grandiosity, the nationalism — are present but contextualized, explained, integrated into a narrative of complexity-that-is-ultimately-redeemed. The result is not dishonest. It is something more interesting: it is a documentary that has solved all

the interpretive problems its subject poses, and in solving them has made the subject less real.

Liu's analysis of affect is useful here. The film produces affect in the viewer: wonder at the sculptures, discomfort at the nationalism, sympathy for the losses, satisfaction at the late recognition. These are genuine responses to genuine material. But affect, in Liu's framework, is not the same as intersubjectivity. Affect flows; it connects surfaces. Intersubjectivity requires differentiation, the acknowledgment that the other is genuinely other — not reducible to what they mean to me, not fully legible within my interpretive framework, capable of being wrong in ways I did not anticipate.

The documentary gives us a Szukalski who is fully legible. His contradictions are there but they have been made narrative. He is not, in the viewing experience, genuinely other. He is an extraordinarily well-realized figure in someone else's story about him. And this is the source of the unreality effect: a person encountered through total mediation by devoted interpreters is a person whose alterity has been managed. He exists inside the love of the people who preserved him, and inside that love he is as complete and as real as a character in a very good novel.

The doubt is not about whether Szukalski existed. It is about whether the documentary's Szukalski and the historical Szukalski are the same entity. And that doubt is structurally correct: they are not. The historical Szukalski produced friction — with institutions, with collaborators, with political movements, with the limits of his own cosmological system. The documentary's Szukalski produces affect. These are different modes of being in the world, and the documentary, by excellence of its craft, has substituted one for the other.

### **The Observer Problem and the Chain of Love**

The UPC framework developed by Eloy Escagedo Gutierrez argues that paradoxes arise when observers are removed from explanatory frameworks. There is a related but inverse problem: what happens when observers are so present, so constitutive of the object being described, that the object cannot be encountered independently of them?

The Szukalski documentary is organized around a chain of observers who are also participants: the people who knew him, loved him, grieved for him, and devoted significant portions of their lives to preserving what he made. This chain of love is also a chain of mediation. Each link in the chain — the photographs Bray collected, the conversations DiCaprio recorded, the documentary Irek Dobrowolski assembled from these materials — is an act of preservation that is also an act of transformation. What is preserved is not Szukalski but what Szukalski meant to the people who preserved him.

This is not a criticism of the film. It is a description of what documentation always does, made visible by the particular intensity of devotion in this case. All archives are partial. All preservation is selection. All documentation reflects the purposes and frameworks of the documenters. But usually these purposes and frameworks are diverse enough that the subject partially escapes them — some witnesses loved the subject, some were indifferent, some were hostile, and the friction between their accounts produces something like an independent object that the various accounts are inadequately describing.

When all the witnesses loved the subject, that friction disappears. The subject becomes the consensus object of devotion, and the consensus object of devotion is, by definition, what the devotees needed it to be. Szukalski's reality — his specific recalcitrance, the ways in which he was not what anyone needed him to be — is present in the historical record but has been largely smoothed into the documentary's arc of tragic greatness and belated recognition.

The observer cannot be removed from the chain of meaning. But when the chain of meaning is also a chain of love, the observer's presence becomes so total that the observed disappears into the observation.

What the documentary cannot show is the Szukalski who was difficult in ways that were not productive, wrong in ways that were not redeemable, ordinary in ways that were not interesting. It cannot show the texture of his actual daily obstinacy — the meetings that went nowhere, the collaborations that failed for mundane rather than tragic reasons, the conversations that were simply boring or repetitive or self-absorbed. These are the friction-producing elements of a real person, and they are exactly what love, in the act of preservation, edits out.

### **Zermatism as an Armillary Proposal Gone Sealed**

Szukalski's theoretical system — Zermatism, with its claims about Protong as the single origin language, its theory of prehistoric interbreeding, its morphological analyses of cultural symbols across unrelated civilizations — can be read as an armillary proposal: a coordinate transformation applied to the questions of human cultural origin, linguistic diversity, and civilizational development.

Read charitably and structurally, Zermatism asks a legitimate question. What if the diversity of human languages and cultural forms is not a branching process of divergence from a common point but a pattern of corruption and fragmentation from a unified original? What if the resemblances between morphologically distant linguistic and cultural systems are not coincidental but trace to a common source that standard comparative linguistics has failed to recover? What if the history of



civilization is better understood as a story of loss than of development?

These are not crazy questions. Versions of them appear in serious comparative mythology, in the study of linguistic universals, in debates about the deep history of human symbolic culture. Zermatism is what happens when these questions are pursued by a mind that has lost the mechanism for encountering disconfirming evidence — when the armillary proposal keeps rotating past the point where it can be checked against the territory it is supposed to be mapping.

The armillary sphere is a navigation instrument. Its value depends on its relationship to the celestial mechanics it represents. An armillary sphere that has been decoupled from astronomical observation — that has become self-referential, its rings encoding relationships that are internally consistent but no longer checked against the sky — ceases to be a navigation instrument and becomes a beautiful closed object. It still looks like a sphere. It still has rings. But it has lost the property that made it useful: its capacity to be wrong.

Zermatism had lost that capacity. It could not be wrong because every piece of evidence that might have falsified it was reinterpreted as evidence of the debasement and confusion it was designed to diagnose. Morphological similarities between distant languages confirmed Protong. Morphological differences were evidence of corruption. The theory was sealed.

This is the pathological form of the armillary proposal, and it is structurally identical to what Liu diagnoses in a different register when she describes the egg avatar's relationship to political discourse. The egg avatar cannot be wrong either — not because its theory is too powerful but because its porousness prevents the formation of the boundaries that would allow genuine disagreement. One has no boundary; the other has a boundary that has become impermeable. Both are sealed against the encounter with recalcitrant reality that is the condition of genuine knowledge.

The connection to the antisemitism is direct and uncomfortable. A cosmological system that posits a debased lineage contaminating pure human stock, developed in interwar Europe by a Polish nationalist, does not require external ideological influence to arrive at antisemitic conclusions. It arrives there through the internal logic of the system once the system has been decoupled from the capacity to encounter disconfirming evidence. The antisemitism is not a foreign body in Zermatism. It is what Zermatism looks like when sealed.

## **The PMC and the Institutionalization of the Sealed System**

Liu's analysis of the professional managerial class is relevant to Szukalski in an unexpected way. Her central argument is that the PMC has substituted the performance of virtue for the exercise of reason — that it has developed a doctrinal system (identity politics, decolonization frameworks, language rituals) that functions as a closed

interpretive system: internally consistent, resistant to external critique, organized around excommunication of doctrinal error rather than engagement with contradicting evidence.

The PMC's sealed system is the institutional form of what Szukalski's sealed system was at the individual level. Both are products of differentiation that has proceeded past the point of productive encounter with the world. The PMC variant is more dangerous in some ways because it has institutional infrastructure — academic positions, editorial boards, grant committees, human resources departments — through which the sealed system can be enforced on people who did not choose to inhabit it.

But the structural similarity runs deeper than this. Liu argues that the PMC's virtue culture is crypto-religious: it has the form of doctrinal systems, with heresy, excommunication, and the performance of correct belief as markers of membership, without the substantive theological content that would anchor the doctrine to anything outside itself. Zermatism has the same structure at the individual level: it is a total explanatory system that accounts for all evidence and is therefore unfalsifiable, organized around a mythology of primordial purity and subsequent corruption that gives its adherent a position of interpretive superiority over those who do not share the framework.

Both systems produce a similar pathology in their adherents: the inability to learn from encounter with the world, because the world has been pre-interpreted by the system. Both systems also produce, paradoxically, a kind of passionate commitment that appears to outsiders as evidence of genuine engagement. The PMC activist who has spent years developing fluency in the doctrinal vocabulary of their movement looks, from inside the movement, like someone who cares deeply. From outside, they look like someone who has substituted the performance of caring for the experience of caring — exactly the distinction Liu draws between genuine maternal attentiveness and its liberal dilution into performative concern.

Sealed systems produce intense internal commitment and impermeability to external reality simultaneously. The intensity is real. It is also exactly what prevents the system from doing the work it claims to do.

What both Szukalski and the PMC demonstrate, from different angles, is that differentiation without the capacity for genuine encounter with recalcitrant reality produces closure rather than integrity. Ego strength that cannot be surprised is not strength; it is rigidity. A cosmological system that cannot be falsified is not a theory; it is a monument to its own construction.

## **Obstinacy, Maturity, and the Problem of the Canon**

Liu argues, following Kant, that democratic citizenship requires maturity — the willingness to use one's own reason, to emerge from self-imposed tutelage, to engage with the world as it is rather than as one's affect-resonance with a group suggests it should be. She notes that contemporary academic culture has largely inverted this value, treating maturity as normative, discipline as oppressive, and the cultivation of permanent infantile receptivity as a form of liberation.

Szukalski's case complicates this picture in a productive way. He achieved something like the opposite of infantile receptivity: a radically individuated creative practice that developed entirely on its own terms, refused absorption into existing movements, and maintained its procedural integrity through decades of institutional destruction and personal obscurity. By the standards Liu is applying, he had strong ego, high differentiation, and a sophisticated capacity for sustained intellectual and creative labor. He was, in the psychoanalytic sense, mature.

And yet the maturity had curdled. The differentiation had become enclosure. The refusal of outside influence, which was the condition of his survival, had also become the condition of his antisemitism and his unfalsifiable cosmology. The strong ego, unmediated by genuine encounter with resistant otherness, had produced a totalizing system rather than a well-developed self.

This suggests that Liu's account, while correct about the pathology of the egg avatar, needs a complementary account of the pathology of excessive differentiation. Maturity is not simply the achievement of ego strength and differentiation. It requires, in addition, the maintenance of genuine openness to encounter — the willingness to be surprised by the world, to be wrong, to revise one's frameworks in response to evidence that does not fit them.

The canon that Liu defends — the tradition of Enlightenment reason, scientific method, Marxist political economy, psychoanalytic self-understanding — is valuable not merely because it represents accumulated knowledge but because it represents accumulated failure. The canon has been wrong. It has been revised. It contains arguments that were superseded, predictions that did not pan out, frameworks that proved inadequate to the phenomena they were designed to explain. This revisability is precisely its value: it is a record of genuine encounter with recalcitrant reality. The Enlightenment tradition did not produce a sealed system. It produced a practice of self-correction.

Szukalski never developed a practice of self-correction. His late repudiation of his nationalist views suggests he was capable of it, but by then the cosmological system that had licensed those views had been in place for decades, and the repudiation appears to have been a single correction rather than the beginning of a revisionary practice. Zermatism survived his moral revision intact.

## Operational Fiber Death and the Lost Warsaw Work

The destruction of Szukalski's Warsaw studio in 1939 is an instance of what the institutional attractors framework calls operational fiber death: the condition in which declarative knowledge of a prior configuration survives while the procedural capacity to reconstruct it decays to measure zero.

The photographs of the Warsaw work exist. Descriptions of it exist. The surviving sculptures provide evidence of the formal vocabulary and the technical methods. But the Warsaw works themselves are gone, and the specific procedural knowledge that produced them — the particular solutions to particular formal problems, the decisions made in the making that are not visible in the finished object — decayed with Szukalski's death. What the DiCaprio circle preserved was the declarative memory. The procedural memory was not transmissible because Szukalski never transmitted it, and when he died it died with him.

This is the irony at the center of his survival strategy. The obstinacy that preserved him through institutional destruction was also the obstinacy that prevented the transmission of his practice to anyone who could have carried it forward. His work survived the bombing because it was entirely his; it could not survive his death for the same reason.

The documentary is itself an exercise in approximate repair: an attempt to recover function — the experience of Szukalski's work, the sense of his creative intelligence, the testimony of people who encountered it — without recovering form. The surviving sculptures are not the lost Warsaw sculptures. The recordings of his conversation are not his creative practice. The documentary is a functional equivalent of having known him, not a restoration of what he actually was.

Approximate repair is what is available when operational fiber death has occurred. The framework developed elsewhere argues that this is a correction of the target for reformers: the appropriate goal is not restoration but functional reconstruction, the design of new forms capable of recovering lost functions in the current environment. Applied to Szukalski, this means that the appropriate relationship to his work is not curatorial — the attempt to preserve and transmit what he made as accurately as possible — but generative: the attempt to understand what questions his work was probing and to continue probing those questions through new work.

Whether the documentary achieves this is uncertain. It achieves something more modest: it makes visible that something was lost, and makes that loss felt. That is not nothing. Making a loss visible is the first step toward understanding what kind of repair might be possible.

## **Reachability and the Sealed Cosmology**

The reachability framework developed in the institutional attractors analysis asks: what futures remain accessible from the current configuration? The parallel question for a creative and intellectual practice is: what revisions remain accessible from within the current framework?

For Szukalski, the answer by the middle of his career was: very few. Zermatism had become a sealed interpretive system that could accommodate any new evidence by reinterpreting it as confirmation of the theory. A practice organized around a sealed system cannot be revised from within; it can only be abandoned or maintained. Szukalski maintained it.

The cost of the sealed system is not merely that it produces wrong conclusions. It is that it progressively eliminates the futures that would have been accessible from a more porous framework. Every year that Zermatism was maintained without revision was a year in which the possibility of a different Szukalski — one who had engaged with comparative linguistics, with archaeological evidence, with the intellectual traditions that might have challenged and enriched his morphological speculations — became less reachable. The admissible set of creative futures contracted as the system sealed.

This is the precise sense in which Szukalski's obstinacy, which was a condition of his survival, was also a condition of his limitation. The institutional independence that preserved him from external destruction also prevented the internal revision that would have kept his intellectual practice alive as a practice rather than a monument. He survived. His practice did not survive him. And the practice did not survive him partly because it had, long before his death, ceased to be a practice in the relevant sense: a mode of inquiry capable of producing surprise.

## **The Tyranny of Affect and the Tyranny of System**

Liu describes the tyranny of affect as the substitution of feeling for objectivity in political and cultural discourse: the claim that shared affect constitutes shared reality, that the intensity of collective feeling licenses conclusions that evidence and argument could not support, that skepticism and dissent are forms of violence against the affective community rather than contributions to a shared project of understanding.

Szukalski enacted a different but structurally related tyranny: the tyranny of system. Where the tyranny of affect refuses objectivity by dissolving the boundary between the feeling subject and the world, the tyranny of system refuses objectivity by totalizing it — by constructing a system so comprehensive that every piece of the world is already interpreted before it is encountered. Both are forms of impermeability to reality. Both produce, in their adherents, a specific combination of passionate

commitment and invulnerability to evidence.

The political consequence of the tyranny of affect, in Liu's analysis, is the inability to build organizations capable of sustained conflict with actual power. Eggs cannot win. They crack against each other before they reach the forces that are actually organizing the world. The political consequence of the tyranny of system is different but equally disabling: it produces certainty without knowledge, action without feedback, and eventually the kind of moral catastrophe that a fully sealed interpretive system licenses when it encounters actual political conditions, as Zermatism encountered the actual political conditions of interwar Poland.

What Liu's account implies, and what Szukalski's career illustrates from the other direction, is that the problem of political and creative agency is a problem of the right kind of boundary. Too soft: dissolution into collective affect, inability to sustain conflict, the egg-avatar politics that cannot build anything. Too hard: enclosure into a totalizing system, inability to learn from recalcitrant evidence, the sealed-cosmology politics that can build things but cannot correct them.

The mediating term — the ego in the psychoanalytic vocabulary, reason in the Enlightenment vocabulary, the practice of self-correction in the scientific vocabulary — is what allows a boundary to remain a boundary without becoming a wall. Szukalski had the boundary without the self-correction. The PMC has institutional structures without the ego functions those structures require to operate as something other than enforcement mechanisms. The egg avatar has neither boundary nor structure.

What is needed is not more differentiation or less differentiation but the capacity to hold a boundary that can also be revised — an ego that is strong enough to sustain encounter with the world and porous enough to be changed by it.

## **The Documentary as Functional Equivalent**

What, finally, should we make of the documentary that produced the unreality effect? The film is, by any ordinary measure, excellent. The sculptures are extraordinary. The testimony of the people who knew Szukalski is moving. The account of the Warsaw loss is genuinely terrible. The navigation of his nationalism is careful and honest without being either exculpatory or simply condemnatory.

And yet the unreality effect is a legitimate response to the film, and understanding why it arises is more useful than dismissing it as uncharitable to the filmmakers. The unreality effect is a signal that something has been managed, that the friction-producing elements of a genuinely recalcitrant subject have been processed into narrative and affect. Szukalski as encountered in the documentary is a functional equivalent of Szukalski — it recovers the function (the experience of his intelligence, the sense of his loss, the encounter with his work) without recovering the form (the ac-

tual texture of his difficult, wrong, obstinate, sealed, sometimes terrible and sometimes extraordinary mind).

This is what approximate repair looks like in documentary form. It is not dishonest. It is the best available approximation given that operational fiber death has occurred — given that the procedural knowledge of what it was actually like to be in a room with him, to encounter his thinking before it had been curated by love, to experience the full weight of his sealed system's implications, is not recoverable. The documentary gives us what it has, and what it has is genuine and valuable.

The unreality effect is what real people feel like when they have been loved into narrative coherence. It is not a failure of the documentary. It is evidence that Szukalski was real — that he was recalcitrant enough to produce, even through the total mediation of devoted preservation, the sense that something has escaped the frame.

Something has. That is what reality does.

## Conclusion

Stanisław Szukalski was too coherent to be real and real enough to exceed his documentation. His creative obstinacy was a survival strategy that worked and a closure mechanism that sealed him. His cosmological system was an armillary proposal that kept rotating past the point of encounter with the territory it claimed to map. His late rediscovery was an act of love that produced, through the excellence of its preservation, a functional equivalent of a man who could not be fully recovered.

Liu's framework gives us the conceptual vocabulary for understanding why: the egg avatar and the sealed system are mirror pathologies of the same failure of mediation, and what is needed in both cases is the ego function — the boundary that can be revised, the differentiation that remains permeable to evidence, the maturity that knows itself without sealing itself against the world.

The documentary's unreality effect is the viewer's correct intuition that they are encountering a functional equivalent rather than the thing itself. The thing itself is gone. What remains is the documentation of the love that preserved what could be preserved, and the sculptures, which still produce the friction that love alone cannot manufacture.

The sculptures are real. They push back. They do not resolve into narrative. They are too strange to be fully explained by any account of the man who made them, including his own.

That is the only kind of reality that survives total mediation: the kind that continues to resist being fully known.

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